and was, therefore, not a natural heir in the direct line of succession.[4] His succession had to be both recognised and confirmed[5] by the Viceroy before there could be an exchange of *kharitas* between the two of them.[6] And then, there was the whole concern over the late Maharaja's adopted son, Raja Jagat Dev Singh, who was also a member of the Council of State.

The Government of India never trusted Maharaja Pratap Singh and, by extension, also mistrusted Raja Jagat Dev Singh. They were not willing to take a risk and give the latter the benefit of the doubt because, technically speaking, he was also of the same bloodline, an equally direct descendant of Mian Kishore Singh, the common great-great-grandfather of Jagat Dev Singh and Hari Singh.

Hari Singh's claim to the throne rested on his father Amar Singh's unwavering loyalty to the Government of India and the latter's perception was that he was a much safer bet for British interests. Of course, future events were to prove otherwise.

Hari Singh first began to reveal his autonomous thoughts by objecting to the government's delay in confirming his succession.[7]He believed that his succession had already been endorsed by both the Government of India and Maharaja Pratap Singh, while he was still alive. He did not buy the government's defence of the distinction between the natural heirs in the direct line and the heirs presumptive, and was dismissive of the process and procedures laid down in the law. The British, however, were sticklers for these details. After much deliberation, and obtaining the Secretary of State's consent, the Viceroy finally presented the *kharita* of offerings[8] to Hari Singh[9] on 14 October 1925.[10] For three long weeks, the issue of succession had remained unresolved. Hari Singh's bitterness towards the British and their tardiness began to colour his perception towards them and their interests.[11] The British were stuck on the horns of a dilemma; to them, their chosen domino had displayed a streak of impatience and imperiousness. Could they continue to trust him? They weighed in on the option of Raja Jagat Dev Singh. Though he had supported his adoptive father in the